were very keen to see it ourselves. We were also clear that we wanted to witness the BJY in the rural areas and not in a big city. So, along with our friends Professor Shantha Sinha, the renowned child rights activist, and M. Vikram, who runs Manthan, Hyderabad's vibrant discussion forum, and some young family members, we caught up with the Yatra at Balanagar, about one-and-a-half hours' drive from Hyderabad. We joined the yatris during their daytime break. Huge tents had been set up in the open ground along the Bangalore–Hyderabad highway. Crowds were milling around outside the camp and the atmosphere was that of a mela. We made our way over very uneven ground to one of the tents. The senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh was sitting casually at the entrance on a plastic chair. The bare ground was covered with mattresses, on which many yatris were sleeping or resting, or just sitting around and chatting. We recognized Yogendra Yadav sleeping on a mattress on the ground.

There were a few folding cots, on which we were seated by the organizers, and soon a small group formed around us of individuals such as Kanhaiya Kumar, whom we knew from his student days in JNU, and Meenakshi Natarajan, a former member of the Lok Sabha known for her integrity and spartan lifestyle; there were also a few others we had not known before. This was the end of October 2022 and the yatris had been walking for almost seven weeks now. They narrated their experiences with great enthusiasm. They did not seem to mind the rather austere and difficult physical amenities that they had access to—they were conscious that they were partaking in a historic event, very different from their everyday lives. The yatris were drawn from different regions, religions, castes and class backgrounds. Thrown together for so many months, they had learnt a great deal about each other's lives and concerns. Friendships blossomed and bonds were forged that would outlast the Yatra. In a country where linguistic, religious and regional boundaries, along with class, caste and gender, most often define social relationships, this was no small achievement. At a time when politics has been reduced to a naked power game, minus people, with acquisition of wealth as its primary objective, and leaders and workers flaunting their expensive vehicles, it was decidedly